



**United
Nations**

Department of
Economic and
Social Affairs



Local E-Government Toolkit

Empowering Local Governments Through Digital Transformation

Participation & Engagement



4. Participation & Engagement

Indicator	Description
1. #250 Municipality responsiveness emails	Responsiveness of the municipality to a set question sent by email / online.
2. #252 Quality of email response	The provision of a useful answer from the municipality to a specific question.
3. #219 Budget-related information	Provision of online sources of information related to its municipality budget.
4. #236 Open data provision	Provision of open data in open formats.
5. #267 Report of any form of discrimination	The ability to report online any form of discrimination.
6. #270b AI-enabled chat-bot functionality	The provision of "AI-enabled chat-bot" support functionality on the municipal government website
7. #271 Feedback/complaint submission	The ability to send a complaint/doubt/feedback to the municipality.
8. #272 Online deliberation processes	The provision of online tools to collect public opinion from people to inform policy deliberation processes.



4. Participation & Engagement (cont.)

Indicator	Description
9. #274 Reporting of incidents in public spaces	The provision of participation possibility to the user regarding reporting of occurrences in public areas/spaces.
10. #275 Participatory budgeting	The provision of participation possibility to the user regarding participatory budgeting.
11. #276 Participatory land use plan	The provision of participation possibility to the user regarding the revision process of the territorial organization.
12. #277 Announcement of upcoming e-participation activities	Information about any upcoming e-participation activities.
13. #278 Feedback about consultation processes	Proof of any outcome of e-consultation that resulted in a new policy decision.
14. #279 e-Voting	The provision of e-voting services to support decision-making.
15. #280 Information on the public meetings of the municipal council.	Provision of information on past and future public meetings of the municipality.



1. Municipality responsiveness emails (#250)

What	Responsiveness of the municipality to a set question sent by email / online form in less than 3 business days.
Why	Crucial for providing timely and efficient customer service, fostering trust, and ensuring residents' concerns are addressed promptly.
How?	Indicative steps: 1. Establish Clear Protocols: a. Create internal protocols specifying the maximum response time (e.g., within three business days) for email and online inquiries. b. Clearly communicate these protocols to all municipal staff responsible for handling queries. 2. Designate Responsibility: a. Assign specific staff members or departments to handle email and online form submissions promptly. 3. Implement Automated Acknowledgment: a. Set up an automated acknowledgment system to immediately confirm receipt of the email or form. 4. Streamline Communication Channels: a. Consolidate email addresses and online forms into a centralized system. 5. Prioritize Urgent Inquiries: a. Implement a system for prioritizing urgent or time-sensitive questions. 6. Standardize Responses: a. Develop standardized response templates for common inquiries to expedite the process.
Guide	Check out the full author's guide .



2. Quality of email response (#252)

What	The provision of a useful answer from the municipality to a specific question by users within three days after sending it.
Why	Demonstrates the municipality's commitment to prompt and effective communication, fosters trust with residents, and ensures their needs and concerns are addressed in a timely manner.
How?	Indicative steps: 1. Establish Clear Protocols: a. Create internal protocols specifying the maximum response time (e.g., within three business days) 2. Designate Responsibility: a. Assign specific staff members or departments to handle email and online form submissions promptly. 3. Implement Automated Acknowledgment: a. Set up an automated acknowledgment system to immediately confirm receipt of the email or form. 4. Streamline Communication Channels: a. Consolidate email addresses and online forms into a centralized system for efficient tracking and response. 5. Prioritize Urgent Inquiries: a. Implement a system for prioritizing urgent or time-sensitive questions. 6. Standardize Responses: a. Develop standardized response templates for common inquiries to expedite the process. 7. Regular Monitoring and Feedback: a. Monitor response times regularly and identify any delays or bottlenecks in the process.
Guide	Check out the full author's guide .



3. Budget-related information (#219)

What	Provision of online sources of information (content or documents) related to its municipality budget (budget or policy)
Why	Crucial for transparency, enabling residents to access vital financial data and policy documents easily, fostering accountability, and promoting an informed and engaged community.
How?	Indicative steps: Select Centralize Information: - Create a dedicated section on the municipal website to house budgetary information and policy docs. - Organize the content into clear categories such as annual budgets, financial reports, policy documents. Regularly Update Content: - Keep the online repository up-to-date with the latest budgetary allocations, financial reports, and policy changes. Interactive Data Visualization: - Utilize interactive charts, graphs, and infographics to visually represent budgetary data. Feedback Mechanism: - Integrate a feedback system where residents can ask questions or request additional information. Promote Transparency: - Clearly outline the municipality's financial priorities, expenditure breakdowns, and policy. - Include narratives and visualizations to explain how taxpayer funds are allocated and utilized.
Case Examples 	Check out Lisbon's budget page .

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4. Open data provision (#236)

What	Provision of open data (datasets) available on the municipal government website or through the portal in open formats (TXT (plain text), CSV (comma-separated values) for spreadsheets.
Why	Enhances transparency, enabling civic engagement, fostering innovation, and promoting accountability, as it allows residents, businesses, and researchers to access and utilize public data for various beneficial purposes.
How?	Indicative steps: 1. Identify Relevant Data Sets: a. Determine which data sets are suitable for public access and align with community interests. 2. Ensure Data Privacy and Security: a. Anonymize or aggregate sensitive information to protect individual privacy. 3. Choose Open Formats: a. Convert data sets into open formats like TXT (plain text) or CSV (comma-separated values). 4. Centralize Data Repository: a. Establish a central repository on the municipal website or a dedicated portal for open data sets. 5. Implement Data Catalog Features: a. Include search and filter options within the data catalog. 6. Update Data Regularly: a. Ensure that data sets are updated periodically to provide the most recent and relevant information. Check out the World Bank's open data toolkit or Open Knowledge Handbook
Case Examples 	Check out Mexico City's open data portal



5. Report of any form of discrimination (#267)

What	The ability to report any form of discrimination (e.g. ethnicity, age, or gender) online, (e.g. declaring a question, concern or complaint regarding discrimination).
Why	Ensures a safe, accessible space for residents to voice concerns, fostering inclusivity and allowing municipal authorities to address issues promptly, promoting a more equitable community.
How?	Indicative steps: 1. Website Development: a. Dedicated Section: Create a specific section on the municipal website for discrimination reporting. 2. Reporting Form: a. Include fields for type of discrimination (e.g., ethnicity, age, gender), date, description, contact info. b. Anonymous Option: Allow anonymous submissions 3. Confidentiality and Security: a. Data Encryption: Ensure that all submitted data is encrypted for confidentiality. b. Secure Storage: Store reported data securely and restrict access to authorized personnel only. c. Confidentiality Assurance: Clearly state the municipality's commitment to confidentiality. 4. Response Mechanism: a. Send an automated email acknowledging receipt of the report. b. Keep the reporter informed about the actions taken and any follow-up. To learn more, check out OHCHR Special Rapporteur on contemporary forms of racism
Case Examples 	Check out London's online page for Reporting hate crime

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6. AI-enabled chat-bot functionality (#270b)



What	The provision of "AI-enabled chat-bot" support functionality on the municipal government website. This can come in as AI-enabled chatbot functionality or Generative AI.
Why	Provides real-time assistance, enhances people engagement, and fosters transparent, improving overall public service accessibility and satisfaction.
How?	Indicative steps: 1. Choose Technology: a. Select between AI-enabled chatbots for structured interactions or Generative AI for creative responses. 2. Data Input: a. Gather relevant FAQs and municipal service information to train the chatbot. 3. Development: a. Build and configure the chatbot based on selected technology and gathered data. 4. Integration: a. Embed the chatbot on the municipal website. 5. Testing: a. Thoroughly test the chatbot for accuracy and user-friendliness. 6. Feedback: a. Implement a feedback system for user suggestions and issues. Check out dacast's guide or touchpoint
Case Examples	Check out Tokyo's AI-enabled chat support



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7. Feedback/complaint submission (#271)

What	The ability to send a complaint/doubt/feedback to the municipality such as, a ""leave feedback"" feature asking for comments on the websites or the services. "Contact the Mayor" feature if exists can count.
Why	Fosters people's participation strengthens accountability and helps municipalities address concerns promptly, ensuring responsive and people-centric governance.
How?	Indicative steps: 1. Placement on Your Website: a. Place feedback features prominently on the homepage and relevant service pages for easy access. 2. Choose User-Friendly Tools: a. Select appropriate tools or plugins that facilitate online feedback. Options include customizable contact forms, chatbots, or dedicated feedback platforms. 3. Customize Feedback Forms: a. Create feedback forms that are clear, concise, and easy to fill out. 4. Implement "Leave Feedback" Buttons: a. Place prominent "Leave Feedback" buttons across your website. 5. Establish a Response System: a. Designate a team responsible for handling feedback. Acknowledge receipt of the feedback. 6. Monitor and Analyze Feedback: a. Regularly monitor the feedback received. Categorize feedback types to identify common concerns. Check out accountablenow's guide and UNHCR
Case Examples	Check out Almaty Feedback page

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8. Online deliberation processes (#272)

What	The provision of online tools available on the municipal government portal to collect public opinion from people to inform policy deliberation processes. "Possible tools include online fora, social media, online polls, online voting tools, online petition tools, chats, blogs.
Why	These tools facilitate active people's participation, ensuring diverse perspectives inform policy deliberations, fostering democratic governance and inclusive decision-making processes.
How?	Indicative steps: Select Online Forums: - Host dedicated forums where people can discuss specific topics. Social Media Platforms: - Utilize social media channels to conduct polls and surveys. Online Polls: - Simple and quick, online polls on the municipal website can gauge public sentiment on various issues. Online Voting Tools: - Implement secure online voting systems for non-binding municipal decisions. Online Petition Tools: - Allow people to create and sign petitions online. Check out UN DESA' paper on E-participation or the OECD's
Case Examples 	Check out Paris' dedicated portal for online deliberation processes. Submit your case here



9. Reporting of incidents in public spaces (#274)

What	The provision of participation possibility to the user regarding reporting of occurrences in public areas/spaces. These initiatives are typically known as ""My street""/""My city"" and are specific initiatives created by the local authority for people reporting about public occurrences (e.g. a hole in the street; a lamp not working).
Why	Empowers people to report occurrences in public areas, ensuring quick response to issues like street damage or malfunctioning streetlights, fostering a safer and well-maintained community.
How?	Indicative steps: Select Website Integration or Mobile App: - Create a dedicated section on your municipal website for these initiatives or Develop a mobile app User Registration: - Allow users to create accounts or report issues anonymously, catering to diverse preferences. Reporting Mechanism: - Provide various categories (e.g., potholes, broken streetlights) for efficient issue categorization. Real-Time Updates: - Implement an automated confirmation system to acknowledge receipt and Provide real-time updates. Internal Workflow: - Establish an internal protocol for municipal employees to address reported issues promptly. Data Analysis: - Analyze the data to identify recurring issues and prioritize them for systematic improvements.
Case Examples 	Check out Brussel's fixmystreet app. Submit your case here



What	The provision of participation possibility to the user regarding participatory budgeting, either in the recent past (up to last 5 years) or in the near future. Many municipalities around the world are starting to engage their people in the discussion of the municipality's budget, known as "participatory budgeting".
Why	Empowers people to engage in crucial discussions about the municipality's financial allocations, fostering transparency, democratic decision-making, and community-driven development.
How?	Indicative steps: 1. User-Friendly Interface: a. Design an intuitive online platform where people can easily access budget-related documents. 2. Transparency: a. Display the current budget, financial reports, and any proposed projects or initiatives. 3. Engagement through Social Media: a. Integrate social media platforms to create awareness about participatory budgeting events. 4. Online Surveys and Feedback Forms: a. Use online surveys and feedback forms to gather opinions and suggestions from people. 5. Clear Timelines: a. Publish clear timelines for the participatory budgeting process. 6. Regular Updates: a. Keep the website updated with progress reports, outcomes of participatory budgeting initiatives.. Check out People Powered's guide or Democratic Society's
Case Examples	Check out Tallinn's page on Participatory Budget Submit your case here



11. Participatory land use plan (#276)

What	The provision of participation possibility to the user, in the recent past or near future, regarding the revision process of the territorial organization (management of the land, converting an area to a park) of the municipality. Many municipalities around the world are starting to engage their people in the processes of revising/restructuring/adjusting the way the municipality's land/territory is organized (this is also typically known as the "Municipality's territorial master plan").
Why	Fosters transparency and ensures community input, aligning urban development with the needs and aspirations of the residents.
How?	Indicative steps: Educate and Inform: - Provide information about ongoing and future projects, proposed changes, and key timelines. Interactive Mapping Tools: - Integrate interactive maps on the portal, so people can pinpoint areas for discussion/improvement. Online Surveys and Polls: - Develop online surveys and polls to gather opinions on various aspects of territorial planning Virtual Town Hall Meetings: - Host virtual town hall meetings and record these sessions to make accessible on the website. Engage Through Social Media: Check out Maptionnaire's guide or Place Changers'
Case Examples	Check out Miami's online zoning callback request page .





12. Announcement of upcoming e-participation activities (#277)

What	The provision of information about any upcoming e-participation activities. E-participation initiatives are initiatives offered to engage people in discussions, decision-making and policy-making. These can be identified through announcement(s), a calendar, of upcoming online consultation, voting forums, surveys, polls, etc.
Why	Keeps people informed and engaged in decision-making, fostering transparency, inclusivity, and active civic involvement in shaping local policies and initiatives.
How?	Indicative steps: 1. Centralized Platform: a. Create a dedicated section on the municipal website for e-participation. 2. Clear Announcements: a. Provide clear and concise announcements about upcoming e-participation activities. 3. Interactive Calendar: a. Maintain an interactive calendar displaying all scheduled e-participation events. 4. Various Participation Tools: a. State what tools can be used for e-participation, online forums, voting platforms, surveys, or polls. 5. Regular Updates: a. Keep the e-participation section updated. 6. Promotion and Outreach: a. Actively promote upcoming e-participation events. Check out OECD's guide or the UNIDO
Case Examples	Check out Bogota's online participation mechanisms (in Spanish).



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13. Feedback about consultation processes (#278)

What	The indication of any actual outcome of online (public) consultation that resulted in a confirmation in policy decision/regulation/service. The outcome can be summary reports, presentation slides, or article updates according to recorded public engagement activities.
Why	Ensures transparency, accountability, and demonstrating the tangible impact of people's input on local governance.
How?	Indicative steps: 1. Update in Real-Time: a. Ensure that the municipal website is updated promptly whenever an e-consultation concludes. 2. Clear Documentation: a. Provide clear, concise, and detailed information about the outcome. 3. Use of Multimedia: a. Utilize multimedia formats such as videos, infographics, or charts to present complex information. 4. Feedback Loop: a. Establish a feedback mechanism where people can comment on the implemented changes. 5. Highlight Impact: a. Showcase the real impact of people's participation. 6. Prominent Placement: a. Ensure that the information about e-consultation outcomes is prominently placed on the website. Check out OECD's guide or the UNIDO
Case Examples 	Check out Madrid's decidemadrid's external website page including results of past consultations. Submit your case here



What	The provision of e-voting services to support decision-making in local government, such as an actual electronic voting tool/process applied to any decision-making process.
Why	Enhances democratic participation, making decision-making in local government more accessible and inclusive for people, ensuring their voices are heard effectively.
How?	Indicative steps: 1. Education and Accessibility: a. Clearly communicate the e-voting process to people b. Ensure the e-voting platform is user-friendly and accessible 2. Security Measures: a. Implement robust cybersecurity protocols to safeguard against hacking and tampering. 3. Verification and Audit: a. Establish a verification and audit mechanism to ensure the integrity of the e-voting process. 4. Pilot Programs: a. Begin with small-scale pilot programs to test the e-voting system. Gather feedback from people. 5. Legal Framework: a. Develop a legal framework, outlining the rights and responsibilities of the government and the voters. 6. Publicize Results: a. After each e-voting event, publicly share the results and any analyses conducted. Check out National Democratic Institute's guide
Case Examples	Check out Tallinn' page on e-voting Submit your case here



What	Information on the public meetings of the municipality council, such as an announcement(s) or a calendar, of upcoming and/or past public meetings of the municipality council or minutes of past meetings.
Why	Enhances transparency, fosters civic engagement, and empowers people to actively participate in the democratic process, ensuring an informed and involved local community.
How?	Indicative steps: 1. Centralized Webpage: a. Create a dedicated section on the municipal website for public meetings. 2. Upcoming Meetings: a. Maintain an updated calendar displaying dates, times, and venues of upcoming council meetings. 3. Past Meetings: a. Archive agendas and minutes of previous council meetings. Organize them chronologically. 4. Live Streaming: a. Whenever possible, provide live streaming or video recordings of council meetings. 5. Notification System: a. Implement an email or SMS notification system. Allow people to subscribe to receive alerts. 6. Public Comment Guidelines: a. Clearly outline the process for public participation during meetings. 7. Regular Updates Check out British Columbia's open meetings guide.
Case Examples 	Check out Madrid's calendar page of the Plenary and the Commissions. Submit your case here



Implementation of participation and engagement indicators in city portals (percentage of cities)

Source: UN
E-Government Survey
2024, UN DESA
These numbers are
represented by the 151
cities assessed for the
2024 LOSI

